4.5.1 Anatomy of a CloudFormation template

A basic CloudFormation template consists of the following five parts:

1. *Format version*—The latest template format version is 2010-09-09, and this is currently the only valid value. Specify this version; the default is to use the latest version, which will cause problems if new versions are introduced in the future.
2. *Description*—What is this template about?
3. *Parameters*—Parameters are used to customize a template with values, for example, domain name, customer ID, and database password.
4. *Resources*—A resource is the smallest block you can describe. Examples are a virtual machine, a load balancer, or an Elastic IP address.
5. *Outputs*—An output is comparable to a parameter, but the other way around. An output returns details about a resource created by the template, for example, the public name of an EC2 instance.

A basic template looks like the following listing.

Listing 4.10 CloudFormation template structure

```
---                                                    ①
AWSTemplateFormatVersion: '2010-09-09'                 ②
Description: 'CloudFormation template structure'       ③
Parameters:
  # [...]                                              ④
Resources
  # [...]                                              ⑤
Outputs:
  # [...]                                              ⑥
```

① Start of a document

② The only valid version

③ What is this template about?